Tandon, a Congress MP from Unnao who joined the SP in 2020, says, "*Bhooke pet bhajan nahin hota* (You can't pray on an empty stomach). There is frustration across the electorate over dwindling incomes and lack of jobs." Akhilesh is very mindful of that, of course, and is seeking to tap into that thirst for better life-chances. In addition to the usual sops for students, he has used the SP manifesto to promise 1.1 million government jobs for the youth, and creating another 2.2 million jobs in the IT sector. For farmers, he is pushing for an assured MSP, free fertilisers and credit with zero interest. For women, besides reservations in government jobs and trebling the monthly pension for the older cohort, he is promising to raise a special force for their security. Former chief secretary Alok Ranjan, who helped draft the SP manifesto, says, "Akhilesh is a visionary who wants to provide world-class infrastructure for Uttar Pradesh, for which he has a proven track record."

It is a spirited fight for sure. But the road from Karhal to Lucknow is still paved with ifs and buts. Psephologist Yashwant Deshmukh, founder-director of C-Voter, feels Akhilesh started his counter-attack too late and didn't do too much for the past two years. "Akhilesh may have become the prime challenger to the BJP, but that is partly because Mayawati has been dormant," he says. "You cannot win an election by default. He is not a Mamata Banerjee, who changed her strategy early enough. He is unlikely to get the vote percentage to beat the BJP." Deshmukh believes the Jats have not voted en bloc for the SP and the alliances Akhilesh stitched together are not delivering as much as he may have hoped for. He also points to the blitzkrieg of rallies Modi is planning to undertake in the final phases that could bolster the BJP's chances, as in 2017. Kulkarni thinks Akhilesh remains a one-man army. "Everything is on his shoulders," he says. "There is insufficient planning and delegation of responsibilities and insufficient messaging on crucial issues. His campaign looks disorganised when compared to his foe's well-oiled party machine. Despite all this, though, it will be a close fight."

What Akhilesh has done, though, is shake the BJP out of its complacency: even if it holds on, it will have been no walkover. One way or the other, the results will carry an effect well beyond the boundaries of Uttar Pradesh. A BJP win will consolidate the country's march towards Hindutva and put the BJP in pole position to win the 2024 election. If Akhilesh pulls it off, it will galvanise Opposition forces across the country. Kulkarni goes even further and says, "It will be the beginning of the end of the Modi era." The stakes are indeed high, not just for Akhilesh but for the country's entire political spectrum. ■



FACE-OFF

THE YOGI AND THE RIVAL IN CHIEF